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Source: *Proceedings of the Indian History Congress*, 1960, Vol. 23, PART I (1960), pp. 89-96

Published by: Indian History Congress

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[13] G. C. Raychaudhuri, *History of Mewar*, p. 41.
[14] Bhandarkar, *List of Inscriptions of Northern India*, No. 1371.
[15] *Ibid.*, No. 18 and footnote on p. 187.
[16] *PAIOC.*, Part I, 1959, p. 176.
[17] Bhandarkar, *List of the Inscriptions of Northern India*, No. 1754; JBORS, VI, pp. 243 ff.
[18] To be published shortly in the *Journal of Oriental Institute*, Baroda.

LAND SYSTEM IN MEDIAEVAL ORISSA (*circa* 750-1200)

RAM SHARAN SHARMA

During early mediaeval times Orissa witnessed the rise and fall of fifteen odd dynasties, many of them ruling contemporaneously. At a time when communications were primitive, the mountainous nature of the greater part of the region helped sustain numerous kingdoms comfortably nested in reasonably defensible areas. Their existence was perpetuated by the predominance of aboriginal tribes, passionately fond of their independence. Several dynasties such as the Bhañja and the Tuṅga seem to have been founded by indigenous chiefs, improvised into respectable kṣatriyas by brāhmaṇical associations,—a practice which still lingers in the neighbouring tracts of Chotanagpur. In Orissa although the rulers of the hilly states owed allegiance to those of the seaboard, the tie was slender and tenuous, and in practice the whole territory was parcelled amongst various ruling houses. The rulers granted land to vassals, officials, temples, and above all to brāhmaṇas, which led to the further subdivision of land in Orissa. The copper-plate land grants, which are more numerous in this State than in Bengal and Bihar during the same period, show that there existed a considerable class of religious grantees and secular assignees, imposed upon the common cultivators.

The secular assignees comprised vassals and officials. Records of direct land grants in favour of vassals are very few, but nearly a dozen terms mentioned in the grants seem to stand for landed vassals. Thus the *bhūpālas*, literally the protectors of earth, may have been important landed barons, who alone were notified of some land grants under the Bhañjas of Khijjiṅga towards the end of the tenth century. Perhaps the aboriginal kingdom consisted of a congery of territorial units, each under a tribal chief (adorned with the Sanskrit title *bhūpāla*), who bore the burden of administration in his district. At this stage under the Khijjiṅga branch there was no place for officials and other dignitaries, who are mentioned in many other Bhañja grants. For some time under the Bhañjas the *bhogīs* and *sāmantas* figure as important elements in the body politic, for only these two dignitaries are addressed in a grant of Vidyādharabhañjadeva.[1] The term *bhogī* occurs frequently in the Bauma-Kara and Bhañja charters. Sometimes it is

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taken in the sense of a village headman, but this office was held by the *mahattara* who worked under the supervision of the *mahāmahattara*[2]; the literal meaning of the term suggests that the *bhogī* did not have to pay any revenues for the land held by him. Perhaps he received assignments in return for some administrative work. In the Bhañja kingdom under Vidyādharabhañja such fiefs were so considerable that the rural people were classified into two units, the inhabitants of the regularly administered districts (*viṣaya*) and those of the assigned areas (*bhoga*).[3] Under a Somavaṁśī ruler the *bhogīs* formed a distinct body known as the *bhogijana*.[4] We also find fief holders, who were as good as *bhogīs* (*bhogirūpa*) but enjoyed limited rights.[5] The *bhogīs* seem to have been connected with revenue administration, and a few of them held the post of the chief accountant (*mahākṣapaṭalika*) under the Bhauma-Karas and were employed in drafting land charters.[6] A superior *bhogī* was known as the *mahābhogī*, mentioned in an inscription of an unspecified family,[7] but in this sense the *bṛihadbhogī* appears frequently in the Bhauma-Kara grants.[8] This officer is understood as a village headman,[9] but in our view he was a higher assignee, enjoying more villages than a *bhogī*. As the *bhogīs* and *bṛhadbhogīs* recur in the Bhauma-Kara grants,[106] we have here a hierarchy of landed magnates.

A graded relation, possibly regulated by the grant of land and the extent of the supply of military aid to the overlord, existed between the *sāmanta* and the *mahāsāmanta*, who were important elements in the dominions of the Bhauma-Karas and their feudatories. A feudatory Tuṅga ruler addresses his land grant only to the *sāmantas*,[11] which shows that only they mattered in administration. The rank of the *mahāsāmantādhipati*, a title applied to the Nanda feudatory Devānanda III (end of the ninth century), was still higher, and he could make land grants in his own right.[12] Whether he assigned fiefs to the *mahāsāmantas* and *sāmantas* is not known. But we have definite evidence that the two successive Bhañja rulers of Khijjiṅga allotted villages to the *mahāsāmanta* Vaṭṭa,[13] whose father Muṇḍi was a *sāmanta*.[14] Apparently the son rose in rank and augmented the fief acquired by his father. Although we have no epigraphic records to show that the *sāmantas* were enfeoffed with land, their later position as an important landowning element in Orissa seems to have been the logical development in the early mediaeval period.

The *rāṇakas* were another group of landholders, possibly serving as military vassals. They were identical with the *rājyanakas*, who were originally members of the royal family, and under the Bhañjas constituted a class (*varga*) by themselves.[15] The epithet *upajīvijana* applied to them[16] indicates that they lived on the bounties given to them by the king. Even persons, who did not belong to the ruling house, came to be known as *rāṇakas* and were granted land. The Somavaṁśī ruler Mahābhavagupta II (1000-15) granted a village to a bṛāhmaṇa *rāṇaka*, whose grandfather had emigrated from Śrāvastī.[17] Some *rāṇakas* were

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assigned more than one village, as can be inferred from a charter by which a rāṇaka under the Gaṅga ruler Vajrahasta (1038-70) regranted a village.[18] This class of vassals held important administrative posts, especially under the Somavaṁśīs. They acted as executors of land grants,[19] chief accountants,[20] and ministers of peace and war.[21] In the feudal hierarchy of the Somavaṁśīs they occupied a high position, preceded by the *rājñī* (queen) and followed by the *rājaputra* (royal prince).[22] The *rājñīs* probably had their personal estates, particularly under the Bhauma-Karas who could boast of six women rulers. This seems to be true of the *rājaputras*, one of whom was endowed with a tax-free village as dowry by a high officer of Vajrahasta.[23] The *rājavallabhas* ranking next to the *rājaputras*[24] were royal favourites, who could not have been rewarded except in the usual way of being favoured with villages.[25]

We can enumerate the different categories of vassal landholders in Orissa: *bhūpāla, bhogī, bhogīrūpa, mahābhogī, bṛīhadbhogī, sāmanta, mahāsāmanta, mahāsāmantādhipati, rajñī, rājyamaka* or *rāṇaka, rājaputra* and *rājavallabha*. Most of them seem to have had military obligations, and they lived on the revenues assigned to them. We have no statistics to find out the relative status and rank of these landowning elements, but certainly their number and importance in Orissa were far greater than in the neighbouring regions.

Quite a few villages were held by the officials, who were allotted land revenues as remuneration. The Somavaṁśī ruler Mahābhavagupta I (935-700) granted four villages in Kośala by three land charters to his brāhmaṇa chief minister Sādhāraṇ.[26] The Nanda king Devānanda III (A.D. 899) granted a village in the Cuttack District to Yaśodatta, his kāyastha minister of peace and war.[27] Two Bhañja rulers of Khiñjali, both brothers, each granted a village to an astrologer (*jyotiṣi*), in the second half of the 12th century.[28] The astrologer, who occupied a high status in the Sena and Gāhaḍavāla list of dignitaries, may have earned assignments from the Bhañjas of Khijiñga, for his services in making calenders. A more secular assignment was made by the Gaṅga ruler Anantavarman Choḍagaṅga (1076-1138), who endowed his trusty agent (*āpta-kriyāya*) Choḍagaṅga with a village along with a hamlet in Kaliṅga.[29]

The typical service grants of the Gaṅga rulers seem to have been made to military functionaries known as *nāyakas*,[30] some of whom were vaiśyas. According to a charter issued in the year 526 of the Gaṅga era under Madhukāmārṇava, son of Anantavarman,[31] three villages were together formed into a *vaiśya-agrahāra* and granted to a certain Erapa Nāyaka, the son of Mañchi Nāyaka of the vaiśya caste.[32] It could not have possibly meant a grant to an army officer for running an educational foundation, a sense in which the term *agrahāra* was used ordinarily in earlier grants; on the other hand it seems to have been an assignment for military service. Some evidence of a grant to a

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nāyaka is also found in an inscription of Anantavarman Choḍagaṅga who made a perpetual grant of a tax-free village to his dependent *Mādhava*.[33] The instances quoted above, though not many, are more numerous than what we find in Bihar and Bengal during this period, and suggest that in mediaeval Orissa civil and military officials were paid by grants of villages, which were also assigned to vassals for military service.

As against a dozen vassals and officials, we have records of land grants to nearly three hundred brāhmaṇas,[34] most of whom seem to have been imported from outside. The brāhmaṇas are addressed in a few Bhañja land grants but not in many others belonging to the Bhauma-Karas, the Tuṅgas, the Somavaṁśīs and the Gaṅgas. Either the areas in which these grants were made did not have any brāhmaṇa population or it was not so numerous and important as to deserve special mention in the grants. The lists of the donees show that they were invited into Orissa mainly from Madhyadeśa, Tīrabhukti, Rāḍha, Vaṅga and Varendra.[35] There is a view that Madhyadeśa, mentioned in the Orissa land grants, was situated between Bengal and Orissa; at any rate there is nothing to suggest that it formed part of Orissa. Some grants indicate that although the brāhmaṇas came from outside they had intermediate stays in Oḍra,[36] from where they were taken into other parts of Orissa.

Generally individual brāhmanas were granted land, but sometimes the number of grantees ranged from two to two hundred. The Bhauma-Kara king Śubhākaradeva I, who flourished in the middle of the eighth century A.D., combined two villages in northern Tosalī into one and granted the unit to two hundred brāhmaṇas of various *gotras* and Vedic schools.[37] This reminds us of a land grant made jointly to one hundred brāhmaṇas by Lokanātha in Eastern Bengal,[38] where Aryanisation by means of land grants had begun earlier. In Orissa this process was especially carried on by some brāhmaṇa rulers such as the Tuṅgas and Gaṅgas. Gayāḍatuṅga, whose ancestors had come to Orissa from Rohtas in the Shahabad District,[39] played an important part in distributing land in the Talcher area to the brāhmaṇas from outside. In one case he granted the fertile land of a village to eleven brāhmaṇas from Ahichchhatra;[40] in another he apportioned out a village among three brāhmaṇas from Varendra, their family originally hailing from Śrāvastī.[41] Thus this avdenturous brāmaṇa ruling family installed several brāhmaṇa landholders in Orissa. Similarly the Gaṅgas seem to have introduced brāhmaṇa landowners in the Telugu-speaking areas of their dominions.

The significance of land grants to brāhmaṇas is not difficult to appreciate. The grantees brought new knowledge which improved cultivation, and inculcated in the aborigines a sense of loyalty to the established order upheld by the rulers, who could therefore dispense with the services of any extra staff for maintaining law and order. In

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return for performing these functions the brāhmaṇa donees were given all fiscal rights, amounting to virtual ownership of land.

Fiscal rights, enjoyed by the rulers and transferred to the donees, were different in backward areas from those in developed areas. Land grants in forest areas were made under the Bhañjas, the Somavaṁśīs and the Gaṅgas. Yaśobhañjadeva of Khiñjali granted a tax-free village called pātikomyāṇa (apparently a non-Aryan settlement) with its trees, creepers, thickets, forest (*araṇya*) along with rights to fishing and catching tortoises.[42] The present village was obviously surrounded by forests or merged into them. A Somavaṁśī charter of Mahābhavagupta IV, who ruled over Western Orissa and Kośala in the beginning of the eleventh century, granted two villages, which were given along with the right of killing snakes (*ahidaṇḍa*) and elephants (*hastidaṇḍa*).[43] Probably the area abounded in elephants, for the district in which the two villages were situated was called Airāvaṭṭamaṇḍala.[44] The locality was inhabited by the Śavaras (now Saoras), noted for their better knowledge of elephants, lions and huge snakes living in the holes and the caves of the hills.[45] The present grant, which was conferred as a fief (*upabhoga*) on two brothers, carried rights to all future taxes (*bhaviṣyatkara*).[46] It is not clear whethr future taxes meant those levied by the king or the donee. But the latter interpretation would imply an extraordinary right, by virtue of which the donees could reduce the villagers to complete serfdom. Some new fiscal rights, appropriate to forest areas, are found in a charter of the last Śomavaṁśī ruler Someśvaradeva. He gave away plots of land (*khaṇḍa-kṣetra*) belonging to two villages, and they carried rights to the enjoyment of ivory (*hastidanta*), tiger's skin (*vyāghra-charma*), various animals (*nānā-vanachara*) as well as different trees such as tamarind and palmyra, along with forests.[47] In all the three above grants the boundaries of the villages were not specified, which left scope for their expansion into the neighbouring jungles. But in a grant of the Gaṅga king Anantavarman the donated village was described as practically surrounded by jungle, trees and rocks,[48] which shows that it was situated in a forest area. Although the terms of this land grant are not laid down, those of others clearly indicate that certain fiscal dues such as rights to trees, forests, hide, fishes, etc., were characteristic of land situated in backward areas.

A striking feature of the land revenue system in settled areas was the transfer by the donors of not only villages with various kinds of dues but also with weavers, brewers, cowherds and other subjects (*prakṛitikaḥ*). The practice was followed by the Bhauma-Kara rulers for about one hundred years from the middle of the 9th century A.D.[49] and also to their feudatories the Bhañjas[50] and Tuṅgas.[51] Of the subjects transferred the mention of weavers and brewers suggests that cloth-making and liquor-making were indispensable rural crafts. Further, the transfer of cowherds points to the importance of pastoral economy in this part of the country. Possibly the transfer of various other arti-

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sans and peasants is covered by the term *prakṛiti,* which stands for the general inhabitants of the village. The fact that they were specifically made over to the donee shows that they were attached to the soil as artisans and husbandmen and in case of oppression by the grantees could not seek shelter in other villages or reclaim virgin areas of which there was plenty in this region. A similar provision occurs in some 12th century Chandella inscriptions,[52] which transfer artisans, peasants and traders to the donees. But in Orissa this practice prevailed on a far wider scale and for a longer period of time. Here it may have been found necessary on account of the scarcity of working population for running rural economy. But such grants reduced the villagers to the condition of semi-serfs, producing surplus for the benefit of brāhmaṇa grantees. Many grantees were allotted *sagulmaka* privileges, which has been taken to mean hunting rights.[53] But the term on the basis of Manu,[54] should be understood as military outposts stationed in the villages by the king, who transferred them to the donees. Control over the local machinery for coercion could enable the grantees to exercise their fiscal rights effectively and maintain the self-sufficient rural economy by means of force. We also notice the gradual undermining of customary communal rights in land. The donors transferred trees, jungles, rivers, etc. to the grantees.[55] Later survivals indicate that in earlier times the villagers had free access to all these local resources, although they were not conscious of their common ownership. But once these were specifically made over to the donees, the latter would not allow its use by the villagers without charging something. Such a practice lingered till the 19th century in U.P., where we find local chiefs levying tax for felling trees.[56] Besides, the villagers could no longer easily reclaim the jungle land for cultivation. On the other hand as the family of the donees would multiply there would be the natural tendency to appropriate the fallow land for their use,[57] thus depriving the peasants of their natural rights to expand into the waste land. This was bound to lead to unequal distribution of land in the villages, the lion's share going to the donees and their descendants. Moreover, they had the additional advantage of being vested with numerous fiscal rights, which in course of time gave them practical ownership of land. This development, however, was not typical of Orissa; the transfer of all agrarian rights enjoyed by the villagers was a usual feature in mediaeval grants of Northern India.

The list of the sources of land revenue, due to the ruler and conferred on the donees, is impressive. But what share of the produce was claimed and how the demand was calculated are not known. Two land grants suggest that assessment was made in money. In one instance the revenue of the whole village granted to a brāhmaṇa was estimated as 44 rupees[58] and in another 42 rupees.[59] In Bengal money estimates first appear in the eleventh century, in the land grants of the Senas. But it is doubtful whether actual collection was made in money either

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in Bengal or Orissa during early mediaval times. Revival of money economy does not seem to have been so strong as to render all payments possible in cash.

The net result of land grants was to create feudal conditions, in which superior landholders were imposed upon ordinary cultivators. These were brāhmaṇas mainly invited from outside Orissa. They not only helped their patrons in maintaining power but also acted as focii of culture, providing moral and ideological anchor to the Hindu rulers in the aboriginal sea. Gradually some aboriginal chiefs also were transferred into feudal vassals. The Māṭhara chief Puñja gas given the titles *samadhigata-pañcha mahāsabda* and *māṇḍalika-rāṇaka*.[60] He was called the *adhipati* (lord) of fifteen subdivisions (*pallikās*),[61] which shows that he was regarded as the owner of the land placed in his charge. Such chiefs, however, did not have the authority to grant land, although one of them, Pulindarāja, was influential enough to prevail upon the Bhauma-Kara ruler Śubhākaradeva (9th century) to grant land for the maintenance of a Śaiva temple and Śaiva ascetics.[62] A third class of landed intermedaries was formed by the holders of service tenures, who were generally assigned land on the same conditions as the brāhmaṇas.

The brāhmaṇa donees, far greater in number than the secular intermediaries, were granted not only the usual fiscal dues to which the king was entitled but also the right of confining the working population to the donated land. This together with the grantees' inroads on the customary agrarian rights enjoyed by the villagers reduced the peasants and artisans to the position of semi-serfs. In mediaeval Orissa all this gave rise to some typical features of feudal land system, which did not arise there on the ruins of any centralised empire, as in parts of Northern India, but out of tribal, aboriginal background in which the aborigines could be assimilated into the Hindu way of life by implanting brāhmaṇa landholders in their midst.

1 *EI*, ix, no. 37, 1.16.
2 *EI*, xv, no. 1, 11. 1-10; cf. D. C. Sircar, *ibid.*, xxix, 85-6.
3 *bhogyādi viṣaya janapadaṁ*, *EI*, ix, no. 37, 11. 16-7.
4 *IHQ*, xxxv, no. 2, Balijhari (Narsinghpur) Copper-Plates, 1. 36.
5 *EI*, xxviii, 323.
6 Binayak Misra, *Mediaeval Dynasties of Orissa* (Calcutta, 1934?), pp. 102-3. no. 12; *EI*, xv, no. 1, 11. 33-4; *JBORS*, ii, 426-7, 11. 40-2.
7 Misra, *op. cit.*, pp. 24-5, Inscr. no. 1.
8 *IHQ*, xxi, 221, 11.27-40.
9 *Ibid.*, 217.
10 *EI*, xxix, 85-6.
11 *JASB*, N.S., xii (1916), 291 ff.
12 *EI*, xxvi, 77.
13 *JASB*, xl, no. 3, 166-8.
14 *Ibid.*, 168.
15 *svavaṁśa-samudbhav-āṣeśa-rājanya(va)rgga*, *EI*, xviii, 29, 11. 17-8.
16 *Ibid.*

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[17] *EI*, iii, no. 47, plate E, ll. 28-42.

[18] *Ibid.*, no. 31, p. 222.

[19] Misra, *Dynasties of Mediaeval Orissa*, pp. 102-3, Inscription no. 12.

[20] *Ibid.*, p. 17, Inscription no. 10.

[21] *Ibid.*, pp. 66-7.

[22] *EI*, iii, no. 47, plate F, ll. 33-4.

[23] *Ibid.*, no. 31, ll, 9-15.

[24] *Ibid.*, no. 47, plate F, ll. 33-4.

[25] R. S. Sharma, *Aspects of Political Ideas and Institutions in Ancient India*, p. 2.

[26] *EI*, iii, no. 47, B. ll, 4-5, C. ll. 4-5, D. 1-5; Fleet *ibid.*, 345.

[27] *Ibid.*, xxvi, no. 26, ll. 19-38.

[28] *EI*, xviii, no. 29, ll. 19-29; xix, 43 & fn. 1.

[29] *Ibid.*, iii, p. 174, ll. 30-4.

[30] *Madras Report on Epigraphy*, 1918-9, Appendix A, no. 3.

[31] *Ibid.*, no. 5.

[32] *Ibid.*

[33] *IA*, xviii, 171-2, ll. 109-113.

[34] This number is based on the list of inscriptions given in Misra, *op. cit.;* since 1934 more land grants have been discovered in Orissa but perhaps they do not indicate any material change in the ratio between the secular and religious vassals.

[35] Misra, *op. cit.*, Index, p. i.

[36] *Ibid.*

[37] *EI*, xv, no. 1, ll. 1-30

[38] *Ibid.*, no. 19, ll-33-50.

[39] *JASB*, NS, xii, 292.

[40] *JASB*, NS, V, 347 ff., ll. 22-20, 33-4.

[41] *Ibid.*, xii, 293-4, ll. 22-32.

[42] *EI*, xviii, 29, ll. 16-22.

[43] *JBORS*, xvii, 1 ff., ll. 29-49.

[44] *Ibid.*, ll. 37-49.

[45] *Ibid.*, ll. 18-21.

[46] *Ibid.*, ll. 37-49. Only the terms of the grant of one village are indicated, but the grant of the second village may also have been governed by the same terms.

[47] *EI*, xxviii, no. 50, ll. 3-8.

[48] *Ibid.*, iii, no. 3, ll. 18-22.

[49] H.P. Shastri, "Seven copper-plate Records, of Land grants from Dhenkanal: G-Grant of Tribhuvana Mahādevī", *JBORS* 42617, ll. 24-32.

[50] *sa-tantuvāya-gokula-sauṇḍhi (ḍi) kādi-prakṛti. Ibid.*, *JBORS*, xvi, 81-2, ll. 18-24; *EI*, xxix, 85-6; *IHQ*, xxi, 221. ll. 28-38.

[51] *EI*, xxv, ll. 12-20.

[52] 239, 115-6.

[53] *sa-kāru-karṣaka-vaṇig-vāstavyam*. EI, xx, no. 4, B plates, l. 19. This is my emended reading on the basis of a land grant of Madanavarman published in a recent issue of *Bhāratī* by V. S. Misra.

[54] H.P. Shastri, *Ibid.*, ii, 426-7.

[55] vii. 114.

[56] *EI*, xviii, no. 29, ll. 19-22.

[57] Baden-Powell, *Land System in British India*, i, 128-9.

[58] *Ibid.*, i, 173.

[59] *JASB*; NS, xii, (1916), p. 295, ll. 22-36.

[60] *EI*, xii, no. 20, ll. 27-8.

[61] D.C. Sircar, *HCIP*, v, 209.

[62] *Ibid.*

[63] *JBORS*, xvi, 81-2, ll. 18-24.

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